

ZPR Policy Delegation

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1. Introduction

In ZPR, policy delegation is the mechanism that allows a central authority to safely share control of network access policy with subordinate policy authors while still enforcing a coherent global security posture. As ZPR deployments grow in size and organizational complexity, delegation becomes necessary to distribute policy authoring without fragmenting control or weakening security guarantees.

In any ZPR deployment of meaningful scale, policy delegation is only one part of the overall network security environment. In addition to policy, ZPR incorporates reference data from trusted services, manages a namespace for services, and enforces authoring permissions for ZPL itself. Each of these components has a delegation component which is managed outside of the ZPR ecosystem but supported by it. In addition, to ensure a secure environment, all of these aspects of the network configuration must be auditable.

The “Triangle of Auditability” diagram below illustrates that a complete ZPR environment involves three separately managed domains.

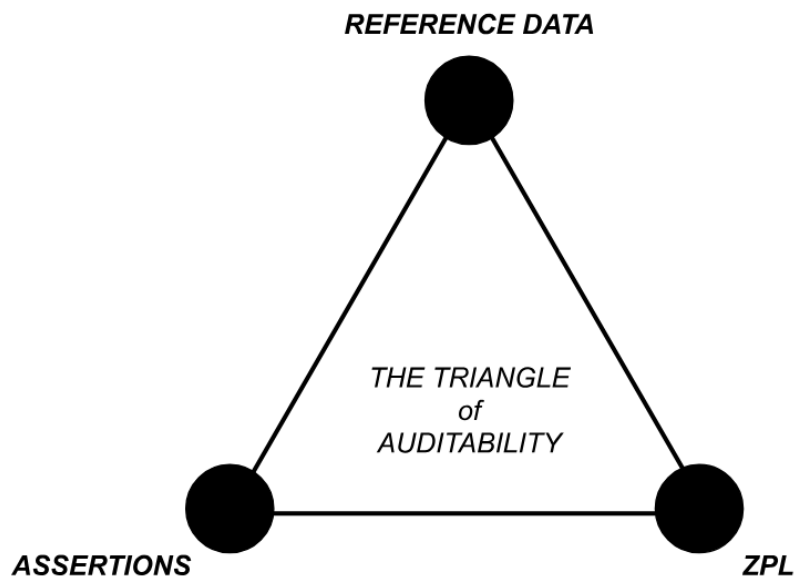


Figure 1: The Triangle of Auditability

The remainder of this paper focuses specifically on delegation support through what we call “realms”. It describes how delegated policy is constrained, verified, and enforced, and how reference data from trusted services is used safely within those constraints.

2. Introducing Realms

ZPR uses the concept of a **realm** to describe the unit of delegation of a ZPR policy. A realm incorporates:

- The namespace (DNS root) for all services.
- Credentials for accessing reference data through trusted services.
- Restrictions on what is allowed to be expressed in ZPL.
- A policy written in ZPL.

When users access services in ZPRnet they do so using DNS names. The binding of names to addresses is a function provided by the ZPRnet. Each realm has a DNS root in which all the defined services can be found.

ZPL always exists in a realm. A simple ZPRnet installation has a single, unnamed realm; explicit realm naming is only required when you want to use delegation.

Within a realm, policy statements can only reference attributes accessible via the realm's credentials, and can only affect services defined within the realm's namespace. For example:

```
Allow interns to access lifecycle:test services
```

In the above services means “services in this realm”.

3. Configuring a Realm

To delegate policy a top level ZPR administrator first needs to organize the service namespace. This step is tightly coupled to service discovery. We use DNS here but other schemes are possible. For example, if the root domain is “corp.com” the administrator may split the namespace into “marketing.corp.com” and “finance.corp.com” with the intention of delegating those service areas to separate groups within the organization. What this means in practice is that the marketing department is free to define services with names like `database.marketing.corp.com` or `addserver.marketing.corp.com`, while the finance department can define services with names like `database.finance.corp.com`, etc.

Next the administrator needs to decide how each realm will access the reference data available on the network. Reference data is accessed through *trusted services*, for example an LDAP service. Access to those services requires credentials which must be specified for each realm. Attributes available to a user with a finance role may be different from those available to a user with a marketing role. This is an organizational IT decision not managed by ZPR, but the support for realm credentials means ZPR adheres to organizational policies.

Finally the administrator can add restrictions to each realm. The restrictions are written in a subset of ZPL: only `never allow` statements and assertions are permitted. As an example, the administrator may include a statement such as:

```
Never allow role:finance services to access internet-gateway services.
```

This prevents finance services from ever communicating with the public internet, regardless of what the realm policy permits.

The key consequence of realm delegation is that when A delegates to B, A defines the service namespace that falls under B's authority and sets the credentials with which B's policy will access trusted services. The delegator always retains the ability to define restrictions for a delegated namespace. A delegatee cannot set policy for anything outside the namespace defined by its delegator.

Since realms use service namespaces it is best practice to leave the assignment of addresses to the ZPRnet itself. That way there can be no accidental duplicate address assignment. However, even if IP addresses are set in the configuration, duplicate address assignment can be caught by the visa service at policy install time.

3.1. Realm Tokens and Deployment

Once the realms are configured, tokens are generated that verify the realm authenticity. For example this could be a cryptographic signature. The purpose of a token is to tie the realm service namespace (a DNS root) to the realm credentials, owner and restrictions in a way that the visa service can validate.

Realm administrator identities and tokens are provided to the visa service by the ZPR administrator. The realm configurations are given to the administrators of the organizational units (in our example, finance and marketing).

To use the realm, each realm holder writes policy in ZPL that is then compiled, validated against its realm, and then can be separately loaded into the visa service which verifies the token before installing the policy.

4. Nested Delegation

If the visa service supports it, the realm system is flexible enough to support nested delegation to arbitrary levels: a delegatee can delegate their namespace to others. For example, the realm owner of `marketing.corp.com` can delegate `it.marketing.corp.com` or any other subdomain as she sees fit.

Restrictions imposed by any ancestor realm are enforced at all levels; a deeply nested delegatee cannot circumvent a never allow rule set by any of its predecessors.

5. Delegation Attributes

Attributes must be carefully controlled in order to keep realm policy from matching things it should not. Within a realm, attributes can be controlled through careful configuration of access credentials and/or through the use of assertions in the realm restriction.

Recall that in ZPL the only way to bind a service to a providing identity is through attributes. Attribute names may be system wide so a realm administrator could theoretically reference attributes outside of their authority unless care is taken. To prevent the binding of services that lie outside of the administrative control of the realm owner you must restrict the attributes in use.

It is perfectly acceptable for the finance administrator to write a ZPL statement to permit marketing users to access some financial service like this:

```
Allow dept:marketing users to access finance-website-01..
```

But, assuming that all the marketing services have an attribute like `marketing-service-role`, this should not be allowed in the finance realm:

```
Define fake-service as a service with marketing-service-role:dbserver.
```

In the above example the finance admin is trying to gain access to a marketing database service. If the finance credential used to access the attribute service is configured to never return the `marketing-service-role` attribute the ZPL will never match anything. With a correctly configured attribute service, the error could be caught at the compiler when it queries the service using the finance credential. Even if the ZPL is not flagged at the compiler stage, and the attribute service is mis-configured, the visa service will refuse to allow the binding of two service names onto the same identity so an error will be raised.

Using a realm specific attribute tied to an access credential as illustrated above is best practice. However, you can also add assertions to the realm restriction that would prevent the delegated administrator from making use of specific attributes:

```
Assert that no service uses the attribute marketing-service-role.
```

6. Compiler Responsibilities

The policy compiler is the first enforcement point for delegation. Given a realm and realm configuration, it is responsible for ensuring that the policy only uses attributes that are allowed for that delegated author.

The compiler determines the set of allowed attributes from the trusted services. That set may then be further reduced by the realm restrictions. These constraints are enforced statically at compile time by generating compilation errors, preventing the creation of a binary policy file. This design prevents a delegated administrator from accidentally or intentionally authoring policy that escapes their delegated scope.

7. Visa Service Behavior

A crucial invariant is that `never allow` rules are enforced everywhere in the delegation hierarchy. When traffic is evaluated, the visa service always denies if a `never allow` statement matches. Policy is evaluated realm by realm, in ZPL policy order. In the absence of a `never allow` the first `allow` matches.

In a non delegated environment, a visa service runs a single policy in what can be thought of as the global realm, and makes decisions based purely on that policy. In a delegated environment, the visa service runs many realms at once.

To support this, the visa service:

- Confirms the proof of delegation associated with each realm, so malformed or forged delegations are rejected.
- Manages access credentials per realm so that services are only instantiated when they match the realms they are defined in.
- Enforces a single service per identity at service binding time.

Each realm maintains its own attribute cache for the trusted services it uses. This keeps attributes in realms isolated from one another and reduces the impact of configuration mistakes. At the same time, the visa service uses global credentials when talking to the authentication service because identity verification is a shared concern, not scoped per realm.

To grant a visa for a specific request, the visa service first identifies the service by comparing its protocol details (address, protocol, port). If the service is bound to a realm, the visa service checks for any `never allow` statements in the realm policy or its restrictions. Then it looks for any `never allow` statements in all parent policies and restrictions. If no `never` statement matches in the delegation chain then the visa service tries to match the request against the realm `allow` statements. If an `allow` is found a visa is granted.

8. Enforcement Guarantees

Trusted services play a key role in enforcement by strictly controlling attribute distribution. They must:

- Only return delegated attributes to the actors authorized to receive them.
- Avoid exposing conflicting attribute sets that would place a service under two different delegated realms.

It is important to note that the strict binding of services to delegated realms only works if attributes are correctly managed in the underlying systems.

While assertions give administrators a way to enforce attribute usage within the ZPR ecosystem, ZPR normally relies on external, trusted services to return accurate attribute sets and to avoid exposing attributes that would give a realm administrator influence outside its authorized scope.

When attribute discipline is followed, the delegation model in ZPR achieves three goals simultaneously:

1. It lets large organizations distribute policy authoring to many admins under central control.
2. It keeps the semantics of delegation aligned with the semantics of normal access control through the use of access credentials.
3. It provides clear, auditable boundaries for administrative authority. Misconfigurations can be detected through verification of delegation tokens, compiler checks, and visa service validation – as long as attribute sources and realm restrictions remain consistent.

9. Revision History

1. Jan 26, 2026
2. May 13, 2026
 - a. Introduce “realm” concept.
 - b. Introduce service namespace and ZPR control of DNS.